

Panasonic bets on apps to catch up with rivals

To woo potential smartphone buyers in India, electronics major Panasonic is working on mobile apps to catch up with rivals like Samsung and Micromax. The company has called itself a late entrant in Indian mobile phone market and plans to roll out the new apps in the next few months.

Samsung smartphone sales back on track

Mobile phone sales have come back to normal in January after a sudden slump due to demonetisation, on the back of quick responses from retailers and marketers. Retailers quickly adopted digital payment options and companies rolled out easy finance options and other consumer offers to help the industry quickly overcome a slowdown.

Japanese electronics brand Akai re-enters India

Japanese consumer brand Akai has re-entered the Indian market and has tied up with a local Indian electronics distributor to begin sales. The company, which enjoyed sizeable operations here in the late nineties through its range of televisions and home theatres, will be retailed by Paras Group that has bought the licence rights for the Indian market.

Trivison plans to expand in India

Europe based consumer electronics and appliances company Trivison is officially launching its brand in India, with 36 branches across the country. The products already launched are LED TVs and home audio, and a complete range of home appliances like washing machines, air-conditioners, air-coolers and air-purifiers will be launched shortly.

Andhra Pradesh to set up EMCs

According to Aruna Sundararajan, secretary of Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) of India, the state of Andhra Pradesh has a huge potential to set up electronics manufacturing clusters (EMCs). Five EMCs were sanctioned for the state, of which two at Tirupati and Sri City in Chittoor district have already commenced operations. Remaining three are coming up at Vizag, Kakinada and Anantapur.

She has also said that the Centre is trying to develop a medical electronics park in Visakhapatnam. The government has allotted around 100 acres in Pendurthi assembly constituency for the project.

She has added that, presently, the information technology sector contributes 10.3 per cent to India's GDP, which the centre wants to in-

crease to 15 per cent in the next four to five years. This transformation will make the country the largest digital identity base in the world.

Odisha jails to be fortified with 4G jammers

Alarmed by last month's twin jailbreaks in Bhopal and Punjab, Odisha government has started the process of fortifying all 91 prisons in the state of Bhubaneswar. To start with, existing 2G signal jammers in most jails will be replaced with high-power 3G and 4G mobile-jamming equipment to curb illegal use of mobile phones by inmates.

Arun Kumar Ray, additional director general (prisons), in a recent letter to the home department, has mentioned that proposals have been received from two empanelled firms, Electronics Corp. of India Ltd and Bharat Electronics Ltd, to upgrade the jamming systems in jails.

Apple to manufacture locally in India

Apple Inc is in talks with the Indian government to explore making products locally in India, as per a report in *Wall Street Journal*, as the American firm aims to make deeper inroads in the world's second-largest mobile phone market. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is trying to boost technology manufacturing in the country through Make in India initiative. His government in June 2016 exempted foreign retailers for three years from a requirement to locally source 30 per cent of goods sold in their stores.

Govt plans to phase out incandescent bulbs

The government has plans to phase out incandescent bulbs by 2020, by putting gradual bans on production and sale starting with high-voltage lamps, and encouraging consumers to use energy-efficient alternatives. Incandescent lamps consume 80 per cent more electricity than LED lamps, but are widely used in smaller cities and rural areas because these cost much less.

Private sector yet to warm up to smart cities

A year after Narendra Modi government selected the first 20 cities for its Smart Cities Mission, reports show that the private sector is yet to warm up to the programme that banks on private support for big-ticket urban infrastructure projects.

EFY'S design community crosses one million on Facebook

The official Facebook page of *Electronics For You* has now over one million fans. Established in December 2010, EFY's Electronics Design Community (EDC) has now become the destination for electronics engineers, hobbyists and enthusiasts for its technology-related discussions on circuit designs and electronics.

Qualcomm invests US\$ 8.5 million in design in India

American chip major Qualcomm has decided to invest US\$ 8.5 million to expand its design initiatives in the country while the government is looking to boost local electronics designing for driving innovation in the country. The investment will go towards Design in India programme to support firms working on rural technology, payment terminals and biometrics devices.

The US company, as part of Qualcomm Design in India Challenge programme, is helping innovators transform their ideas in its Innovation Lab in Bengaluru to prototypes. The initiative is on the backdrop of Narendra Modi-led NDA government's push to increase local design capabilities under Make in India initiative.